

Horse Riding - Understanding Your Coach

Name: _____

Date: _____

1. Pre-teach: 20 words you'll actually hear from a coach

#	Word / phrase	Meaning
1	walk on	command: move forward
2	halt / whoa	command: stop
3	trot on	command: ask the horse to trot (a bouncy, two-beat gait)
4	rising trot	standing slightly out of the saddle and sitting back down in rhythm with the trot, to make it more comfortable
5	heels down	keep your heels lower than your toes in the stirrups
6	sit up straight	keep your back straight, don't lean forward or back
7	eyes forward	look ahead, not down at the ground
8	squeeze (your legs)	press gently with your legs to ask the horse to move
9	hold the reins	keep the leather straps in your hands, to guide the horse
10	relax your shoulders	loosen up, don't tense your shoulders
11	mount	get on the horse
12	dismount	get off the horse
13	mounting block	a step used to help a rider get on the horse safely
14	stirrup	the metal loop your foot rests in
15	girth	the strap that holds the saddle in place under the horse
16	reins	the straps used to guide the horse
17	saddle	the seat you sit in on the horse's back
18	riding hat / helmet	protective headgear – always worn while riding (UK riders often say "hat")
19	aids	the signals a rider gives a horse (legs, hands, voice, weight)
20	arena	the enclosed area where lessons take place

2. Reading (5-7 min)

Your first riding lesson usually starts on the ground, not in the saddle. Your instructor will show you how to approach the horse calmly, how to check your helmet and stirrups, and how to mount safely. Once you're on, the most important thing is your position: heels down, back straight, eyes forward. Your instructor will ask you to squeeze gently with your legs to walk on, and to sit back and relax your shoulders when they ask you to halt. Listening carefully matters – a horse feels every small signal you give it, on purpose or by accident, so a clear instruction from your coach is what keeps both you and the horse safe and comfortable.

Comprehension questions: 1. What happens before a rider even gets on the horse? 2. Name two things your position should include. 3. What do you do with your legs to ask the horse to walk on? 4. Why does the text say listening carefully "matters"?

3. Writing (5-7 min)

Choose one: - **A.** Write 5 instructions your coach might give you during your first lesson, using at least 5 words from the list above. - **B.** Write a short diary entry (6-8 sentences) titled "*My first riding lesson*", imagining what happened, using at least 6 words from the list.

4. Oral comprehension - video task (8-10 min)

- Compare lists in pairs – did you hear the same commands?
- True/false check (adapt once you've previewed the video), e.g.: "*The instructor tells the rider to look down.*" (False – eyes forward)

5. Oral expression: imperative vs diplomatic register

Real coaches mostly use **imperative** commands – direct and practical. But politer, more indirect language exists too, and it's worth recognising both. Items marked are for B1-B2 students; everyone should be comfortable with the plain imperative column.

Imperative (everyone)	Diplomatic (B1-B2)
Walk on.	Could you walk on, please?
Halt.	Could you bring her to a halt?
Heels down.	Would you mind putting your heels down?
Sit up straight.	Could you sit up a little straighter for me?

Imperative (everyone)	Diplomatic (B1-B2)
Eyes forward.	Would you look up, please?
Squeeze with your legs.	Could you give a gentle squeeze with your legs?
Hold the reins higher.	May I ask you to hold the reins a bit higher?
Relax your shoulders.	Could you relax your shoulders for me?
Mount now.	Would you like to mount now?
Dismount here.	Shall we dismount here?

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Videos found (preview before using - I can't watch them myself)

1. **How To Ride A Horse | Horse & Hound** - <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=V2FaPPXF1Lk> **British English, British terminology** (Horse & Hound is a UK equestrian magazine) - covers mounting, aids, walk, and rising trot, with the actual commands used ("trot on", "walk"). Clear to-camera narration, predictable structure. **Primary recommendation** - matches both the accent your students will actually hear at St Mary's and the vocabulary list below almost word for word.
2. (Optional, B1-B2 only) **Sample Lesson on First Trot, with Andrea Boone** - https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=TY_jar0Tywo A real 15-minute lesson with an actual student - useful for exposure to a live, unscripted instructor-student exchange, but note it's **American English**, so flag the accent difference explicitly if you use it (could even be a short discussion point: "same sport, different accent, some different words").

6. Game / role-play (10 min)

"Coach Says" (Simon Says, horse-riding edition) - One student is the coach, the rest mime being riders (sitting on an imaginary horse, or actually miming with a chair). - The coach calls out commands from the list above. Riders only obey if the command is preceded by *"Coach says..."* - otherwise they must freeze. Anyone who moves on a command without "Coach says" is out. - **Twist for B1-B2 students:** the coach can also use the diplomatic versions - riders still have to recognise them as the same instruction and react.

Alternative / extension - "Walk on, Halt!" (Red Light, Green Light, horse-riding edition) - One "coach" stands at the front and calls "Walk on!" (everyone moves forward) or "Halt!" (everyone freezes instantly). Last one moving after "Halt" is out, or gets a point deducted. Good energy-burner if the group needs to move after a long listening task.

Once this template is validated, I'll adapt the same structure for tennis and basketball - same six sections, same imperative/diplomatic star system, different vocabulary and video.

About this activity

Template activity (to be adapted for tennis and basketball) - all four skills, one theme ~45-50 min total, can be split across two sessions

1. Pre-teach: 20 words you'll actually hear from a coach

Matching worksheet - paste this list into the Daily Vocabulary Generator (Day 1 matching / Day 2 test) or use as-is.

2. Reading (5-7 min)

Short text – hand out or project. Ask comprehension questions after (below).

4. Oral comprehension - video task (8-10 min)

While watching, students note down (individually or in pairs) every ****command**** the coach gives (aim for at least 6). After watching: